through Pakistan. China wanted to support Pakistan in the conflict but not to such an extent that it would undermine a close Chinese relationship with a future independent Bangladesh.[41] Moreover, the Indo–Soviet Treaty of Friendship signed in August 1971 during the East Pakistan crisis was interpreted by Beijing as a sign of India joining the Soviet Union in an anti-China arc in Asia while simultaneously expanding its own power in South Asia.[42]

China's improved relationship with the United States made it less likely that India or the Soviet Union would attempt to undermine its position in Tibet.[43] However, with India going nuclear in 1974, annexing Sikkim in 1974–75, and welcoming an increasing number of Soviet naval vessels into Indian ports, while the United States departed Indochina in 1975 and in general turned more isolationist, China felt pressured to take initiatives to counter Indian and Soviet strategy.[44] First and foremost, after the 1971 creation of Bangladesh out of East Pakistan, Beijing continued its proxy balancing by supporting Islamabad to rebuild its military and provided assistance to its nuclear programme and later also its missile programme.[45] Furthermore, throughout the 1970s and 80s, in an attempt to reduce India's power in the region, China supported other South Asian countries against India "in whatever conflicts of interest came along."[46] From 1975 onwards, China established a close relationship with Bangladesh, and, between 1971, when Bangladesh was established, up to 1989, China accounted for as much as 65 percent of its weapons imports.[47] In the 1980–1995 period, China provided 26 of the total 29 navy vessels purchased by Bangladesh.[48] With regard to Burma, in parallel to its support to the military regime, China provided substantial aid to the communist insurgency in Burma,[49] but China's military cooperation with Burma/Myanmar did not develop fully until after 1989. China also heavily increased its foreign aid to Nepal in the mid-1960s and towards the late 1970s almost